

REGULAR EXPRESSIONS

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THEY CALL ME REGEX

AND I'M NOT YOUR AVERAGE SEARCH

Regular Expressions are an essential tool for string manipulation. They allow searching for occurrences of a pattern instead of a specific word, sentence or number.

WHY?

Regex comes in handy when dealing with large data sets.

Using these expressions, one will be able to search for something without knowing its exact characters.

WAIT... WHAT?!
EXAMPLES ALWAYS HELP

You've got a user list.

Each user is identified by a group of information:

- First Name
- Last Name
- Age
- E-mail
- Telephone Number

CAN I GET YOUR NUMBER?

Your boss needs every telephone number on the list.

What would you do?

If you said "I'd use those Regular Expressions", you're on the right track!

ON THE RIGHT TRACK, YOU SAY?

Every telephone number is different, right? But every telephone number consists of nine digits. A pattern.

Using Regex you may search for that specific pattern, gathering everything that matches it.

This is a huge time-saver, and is easily achieved by a simple regular expression.

VALID DATA, PLEASE.

The pattern-searching ability of Regex also allows us to use it as a validation tool.

Looking for a pattern means we can filter out data that does not meet our requirements.

In the previous example, we could have gathered all the numbers by searching for a 9-digit pattern. This means if a user had a number with less than 9 digits, it would not show up in the results. (and that's good)

WHERE DO I INSERT THOSE EXPRESSIONS?

Regex is supported in a variety of programming languages, natively or through libraries.

Even your terminal is capable of understanding regular expressions, and we'll use it for this exercise.